

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Christianity as a lived religion in the United Kingdom and throughout the world.

There are four sections: Beliefs and Teachings; Practices; Sources of Wisdom and Authority; Forms of Expression and Ways of Life.

Students will be expected to study Christianity within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian.

Students should recognise that Christianity is one of the many religious traditions in Great Britain which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism and Sikhism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content. Students should compare and contrast two areas of belief and practice within Christianity with one of these religions practiced in Great Britain:

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.6)*
- The practice and significance of worship (2.1)*.

Students should also recognise that within Christianity there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Christianity in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant and other Christian traditions.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs and practices to Christians today should be explored throughout the four sections.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The Trinity: the nature and significance of the Trinity as expressed in the Nicene Creed; the nature and significance of the oneness of God; the nature and significance of each of the Persons individually, including reference to Matthew 3:13–17; how this is reflected in Christian worship and belief today.
1.2	The creation of the universe and of humanity: the biblical account of creation and divergent ways in which it may be understood by Christians, including as literal and metaphorical; the role of the Word and Spirit in creation, including John 1:1–18 and Genesis 1–3; the importance of creation for Christians today.
1.3	The Incarnation: the nature and importance of the person of Jesus Christ as the incarnate Son of God; the biblical basis of this teaching, including John 1:1–18 and 1 Timothy 3:16 and its significance for Christians today.
1.4	The last days of Jesus' life: the Last Supper, betrayal, arrest, trial, crucifixion, resurrection and ascension of Jesus; the accounts of these within the Bible, including Luke 22–24 and the significance of these events to understanding the person of Jesus Christ.
1.5	The nature and significance of salvation and the role of Christ within salvation: law, sin, grace and Spirit, the role of Christ in salvation, including John 3:10–21 and Acts 4:8–12; the nature and significance of atonement within Christianity and its link to salvation.
1.6*	Christian eschatology: divergent Christian teachings about life after death, including the nature and significance of resurrection, judgment, heaven, and hell and purgatory, with reference to the 39 Articles of Religion and Catholic teachings; how beliefs about life after death are shown in the Bible, including reference to 2 Corinthians 5:1–10 and divergent understandings as to why they are important for Christians today.
1.7	The problem of evil/suffering and a loving and righteous God: the problems it raises for Christians about the nature of God, including reference to omnipotence and benevolence, including Psalm 103; how the problem may cause believers to question their faith or the existence of God; the nature and examples of natural suffering, moral suffering.
1.8	Divergent solutions offered to the problem of evil/suffering and a loving and righteous God: biblical, theoretical and practical, including reference to Psalm 119, Job, free will, vale of soul-making, prayer, and charity; the success of solutions to the problem.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1*	Christian worship: liturgical and non-liturgical forms of worship, including activities which are informal and individual, with reference to the <i>Book of Common Prayer</i> ; when each form might be used and why; divergent Christian attitudes towards the practices, meaning and significance of liturgical and non-liturgical forms of worship in Christian life today, with reference to denominations which worship with less structure such as some Pentecostal churches.
2.2	The role of the sacraments in Christian life and their practice in two denominations: the role of the sacraments/ordinance as a whole; the nature and importance of the meaning and celebration of baptism and the Eucharist in at least two denominations, including reference to the 39 Articles XXV–XXXVI; divergent Christian attitudes towards the use and number of sacraments in Orthodox, Catholic and Protestant traditions.
2.3	The nature and purpose of prayer: the nature of and examples of the different types of prayer; set prayers; informal prayer and the Lord's Prayer, including Matthew 6:5–14; when each type might be used and why; divergent Christian attitudes towards the importance of each type of prayer for Christians today.
2.4	Pilgrimage: the nature, history and purpose of pilgrimage, including interpretations of Luke 2:41–43; the significance of the places people go on pilgrimage; divergent Christian teachings about whether pilgrimage is important for Christians today, with specific reference to Catholic and Protestant understandings; the activities associated with, and significance of, Jerusalem, Iona, Taizé and Walsingham.
2.5	Christian religious celebrations: the nature and history of Christian festivals in the church year, including Christmas and Easter; the significance of celebrating Advent and Christmas; the significance of celebrating Holy Week and Easter, with reference to interpretations of 1 Corinthians 15:12–34.
2.6	The future of the Christian Church: Church growth, the history and purpose of missionary and evangelical work, including reference to Mark 16:9–20; divergent ways this is put into practice by the Church locally, nationally and globally; Christian attitudes to why evangelical work is important for the Church and for individual Christians.
2.7	The role and importance of the local church in the local community: how and why it helps the individual believer and the local area; local parish activities, including interpretations of 1 Peter 5:1–4, ecumenism, outreach work, the centre of Christian identity and worship through living practices.
2.8	The role and importance of the Church in the worldwide community: how and why it works for reconciliation and the problems faced by the persecuted Church; divergent Christian responses to teachings about charity, including 1 Corinthians 13 and Matthew 25:31–46; the work of Christian Aid, what it does and why.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	The development and structure of the Bible and its unity as the Word of God: Old Testament: law, history, prophets, writings; and New Testament: gospels, letters; divergent interpretations of the authority of the Bible; the Bible as the literal Word of God, the inspired Word of God, source of guidance and teaching, including 2 Timothy 3:16 and Dei Verbum Chapter 3; the implications of these understandings for Christians today.
3.2	Divergent ways in which the Bible is used in the daily life of a Christian: informal and formal worship with reference to the <i>Book of Common Prayer</i> , in the home, in the Church, as a source of comfort and guidance.
3.3	Divergent responses to sources of personal and ethical decision making by Christians, their significance and their inter-relationship: the use of the Bible, the role of the individual, reason and personal conscience, including the Catechism of the Catholic Church 1777–1781.
3.4	Jesus as the Word of God, including John 1 and a role model: beliefs and teachings about Jesus as the Word of God; divergent understandings of his role in modelling practices, including Mark 8:34–38; the divergent implications of Jesus' example in showing love for others, forgiveness, servanthood, reconciliation and social justice, and in establishing the Kingdom of God, the significance of these beliefs for Christians today.
3.5	The Church as the Body of Christ: understandings of the significance of the Church as the Body of Christ and the People of God; the nature of the Church as the Body of Christ, including Romans 12:4–6 and 1 Corinthians 12; divergent ways in which this belief is important for Christians today, including in understanding the nature of the growth and diversity of the Church.
3.6	The growth and development of the Church: the establishment, development and growth of the Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant and Pentecostal/Charismatic Churches; changes in the Church as the Body of Christ, including interpretations of 1 Corinthians 12, the Filioque controversy and the Reformation; and divergent understandings of the significance of the development of diverse denominations within the Church today.
3.7	Leaders and leadership in the Church: the laity, ministers (priests/vicars/pastors), bishops and the pope; the roles and significance of each, including Ephesians 4:11–12 and Lumen Gentium Chapters 4 and 5; divergent ways in which the leaders support and interact with one another in different denominations; divergent understandings of the importance of each of these leaders in different Christian traditions.
3.8	The role of women in the Church: divergent understandings of the basis of roles within the Bible, including interpretations of 1 Corinthians 14:33–40 and Romans 16:1–16; the historical development of attitudes towards women as leaders, and the different roles of women today in the Church and Christian life; divergent approaches to the role of women in different denominations.